3.1

Back to Soldiering: The First Star

After dispatching our luggage by container ship, we shifted to a hotel for the last few days, having handed over charge to Col Rajesh Kumar of the Rajput Regiment. We handed over the house, bid farewell to the staff and moved out. Dates for the general elections, the first in more than two decades, had been announced for November 2010, and there was a suppressed sense of both excitement and trepidation in the air. I too had my farewell round of parties and call-ons. By now, the new National Parliament building at Naypyitaw, the Pyidangsu Hlutaw, which had been under construction, had been inaugurated. It was an imposing structure meant to overawe visitors. My last call was on Vice Senior General Maung Aye, in the main reception hall. It was a huge room with flags on either side. In the middle of the hall, two chairs had been placed, with the national flags of both countries on a small table placed in between. Nothing else. I walked into this huge, cavernous hall with my boots clicking on the polished marble floor and saluted the Vice Senior General, who was already present in the room. We chatted for a few minutes one-on-one, and the Vice Senior

Copyright © Penguin Random House India
Not for circulation

Four Stars of Destiny.indd 179 11/28/2023 12:45:15 PM